

CSCI 3921W - Social, Legal, and Ethical Issues in Computing

Ethics Analysis Exercise

Suppose it is obvious that someone in need should be helped. A utilitarian (consequentialist) will point to the fact that the consequences of doing so will maximize well-being, a deontologist to the fact that, in doing so the agent will be acting in accordance with a moral rule such as “Do unto others as you would be done by” and a virtue ethicist to the fact that helping the person would be charitable or benevolent.” – [Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy](#)

Group Activity

Each group will analyze the same technology from different ethics perspectives/frameworks.

In your group, answer the questions under your assigned framework. Be prepared to share your analysis with the class.

Technology: **ONLINE LEARNING WITH FACIAL EMOTION ANALYSIS**

Consequentialism

Steps

1. Identify everyone involved
2. Identify effects of the ethical decision, both positive and negative
3. Weigh the effects: is the net effect beneficial or harmful?

Guiding Questions

1. Who will be affected? Consider individuals and groups of people (identify stakeholders)
2. Who might use this product that we didn't expect to use it, or for purposes we didn't initially intend? (expand stakeholders)
3. What are the benefits of this technology?
4. What are the negative side effects or risks of this technology?
5. Who receives the benefits of this technology, and who bears the brunt of the negative side effects or risks?
6. Would a different technological design or abstaining from the technology altogether yield a better overall outcome for society?

Deontology

Kant's categorical imperative

1. Act in a way that can form a universal rule that is always applicable to everyone.
2. Treat humanity, whether in your own person or in another, always as an end and never as only a means.

Guiding Questions

1. If everyone in the world used this technology (universalization of the action) would that create a logical contradiction? Would that be immoral?
2. How does this technology respect the intrinsic value and autonomy of every person?
3. How does this technology use people as a tool to accomplish something?

Virtue Ethics

Vallor's Technomoral Virtues

Cultivated moral habits designed to help humans adapt, survive, and flourish:

- honesty – respecting truth
- self-control – be the author of our own desires rather than letting algorithms dictate them
- humility – know the limits of our technical knowledge and power
- justice – distribute fairly benefits and risks
- courage – navigate risks
- empathy – display compassionate concern for others
- care – tend to the well-being of others
- civility – live well together
- flexibility – adapt behavior in dynamic situations
- perspective – discern the big picture, ignore noise
- magnanimity – be noble
- technomoral wisdom – integration of all the virtues. Includes not only the wisdom to make good moral choices when confronted with an ethical issue, but also an understanding of both relevant technical and social aspects of technology.

Vallor, S. (2016). *Technology and the virtues: A philosophical guide to a future worth wanting* (Vol. 10). Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Guiding Questions

1. How does this technology cultivate positive human traits (like empathy, patience, honesty, and wisdom)?
2. How does this technology feed vices (like impatience, arrogance, superficiality, or cruelty)?
3. How does this technology support genuine human excellence and connection?
4. How does this technology elevate or degrade our capacity for deep thought, physical presence, and self-reliance? (add here any other relevant virtues)

Contractualism

1. How does this technology sustain or violate fundamental human rights? Some human rights: privacy, informed consent, bodily autonomy, or dignity)? You can consult the [UN's Universal Declaration of Human Rights](#) for a more complete list
2. How does this technology sustain or violate other societal norms and rules?

References

[An Ethical Toolkit for Engineering/Design Practice](#)

[Ethics & Algorithms Toolkit: A risk management framework for governments \(and other people too!\)](#)

[Unesco's Ethical Impact Assessment](#)